Clean Inside and Out

God looks past religious appearances to the heart; Jesus calls us to put first things first and to let him cleanse us from the inside out.

Main passage	Matthew 23:23-28 (KJV)
Topic	Hypocrisy
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Do not major on minors	7 min
Teaching point 2: Clean the inside first	7 min
Teaching point 3: Do not be a whitewashed tomb	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Show (or describe) a polished apple with a bruise or worm hole on the inside. Ask: "What matters more about an apple, how it looks or what is inside?" Then ask: "Why are we so concerned with how we look to other people?" Today Jesus speaks some of his strongest words to the most respected religious people of his day.

Teacher note: Jesus' words here are severe. Make sure the class sees that the warning is for us and our churches, not just for "those Pharisees" long ago.

Scripture (3 min)

Matthew 23:23-28

23 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the weightier matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone. 24 Ye blind guides, which strain at a gnat, and swallow a camel. 25 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye make clean the outside of the cup and of the platter, but within

they are full of extortion and excess. [26] Thou blind Pharisee, cleanse first that which is within the cup and platter, that the outside of them may be clean also. [27] Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye are like unto whited sepulchres, which indeed appear beautiful outward, but are within full of dead men's bones, and of all uncleanness. [28] Even so ye also outwardly appear righteous unto men, but within ye are full of hypocrisy and iniquity.

Read the passage aloud.

Background (5 min)

Matthew 23 is the last public teaching of Jesus in Matthew. It includes seven "woes" against the scribes and Pharisees. The Pharisees were not villains in their own eyes; they were the most devout people around, serious about Scripture and holy living. Jesus even told people to heed their teaching (23:2-3). His charge was that they said but did not do, and did for show.

Barnes and Clarke both point out that "strain at a gnat" should read "strain out a gnat." Strict Jews poured their drink through a cloth so they would not swallow a tiny unclean insect. The camel was the largest unclean animal they knew. Tombs were whitewashed so people would see them and avoid touching them, which made a person ceremonially unclean (Numbers 19:16).

Teaching point 1: Do not major on minors (7 min)

The Pharisees carefully tithed even their garden herbs, but neglected "judgment, mercy, and faith." Jesus does not say small things do not matter: "these ought ye to have done." He says the weightier matters come first. It is possible to be careful about details and careless about justice, mercy and faithfulness.

Supporting verses

Matthew 23:23-24: Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the weightier matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone. Ye blind guides, which strain at a gnat, and swallow a camel.

Micah 6:8: He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?

Luke 11:42: But woe unto you, Pharisees! for ye tithe mint and rue and all manner of herbs, and pass over judgment and the love of God: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone.

> *"They were remarkably scrupulous in the performance of all the rites and ceremonies of religion, but totally neglected the soul, spirit, and practice of godliness."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 23:23

Handout blanks (answers)

The weightier matters of the law are judgment, **mercy**, and faith.

They strain out a gnat and swallow a **camel**.

Teaching point 2: Clean the inside first (7 min)

A cup polished on the outside but dirty inside is useless for drinking. The Pharisees washed carefully but were full of greed and self-indulgence within. Jesus' remedy is not more polish but a change of heart: "cleanse first that which is within." Only God can do that, by forgiveness and the new heart he gives.

Supporting verses

Matthew 23:25-26: Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye make clean the outside of the cup and of the platter, but within they are full of extortion and excess. Thou blind Pharisee, cleanse first that which is within the cup and platter, that the outside of them may be clean also.

Psalm 51:10: Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me.

Ezekiel 36:26: A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh.

> *"the principal care of every one of us should be to wash our hearts from wickedness"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 23:13-33

Handout blanks (answers)

Cleanse first that which is **within** the cup.

Only God can give us a clean **heart**.

Teaching point 3: Do not be a whitewashed tomb (7 min)

Whitewashed tombs look clean and bright, but inside they are full of dead men's bones. Jesus says some people "appear righteous unto men" while inside they are full of hypocrisy. God is not fooled by appearances. The good news is that he does not want us to stay that way. Honest confession is the opposite of hypocrisy.

Supporting verses

Matthew 23:27-28: Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye are like unto whited sepulchres, which indeed appear beautiful outward, but are within full of dead men's bones, and of all uncleanness. Even so ye also outwardly appear righteous unto men, but within ye are full of hypocrisy and iniquity.

1 Samuel 16:7: But the LORD said unto Samuel, Look not on his countenance, or on the height of his stature; because I have refused him: for the Lord seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.

1 John 1:8-9: If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

> *"It is possible for those that have their hearts full of sin, to have their lives free from blame, and to appear very good."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 23:13-33

> *“But what will this appearance avail a man, when God sits in judgment upon his soul?”*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 23:28

Handout blanks (answers)

Ye outwardly appear **righteous** unto men.

The opposite of hypocrisy is honest **confession**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What "gnats" do churches sometimes strain out while swallowing "camels"?

Arguments over small matters of style or procedure while neglecting justice, mercy, faithfulness, or care for people.

2. Why is it so easy to care more about how we look than about our hearts?

We see others' opinions immediately; we fear exposure; image is easier to manage than inner change.

3. How can a church become a place where people do not need to pretend?

Leaders modelling honesty, confession, grace for failures, small groups where people can be known.

4. If only God can clean the inside, what is our part?

Honest confession, repentance, asking for his cleansing, and living by his Spirit.

Application (3 min)

Pray Psalm 139:23-24 every day this week: "Search me, O God, and know my heart." Ask God to show you one area where your outside and inside do not match. Confess it to him, and if it would help, to a trusted Christian friend.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Holy God, you see our hearts. Forgive us for caring more about how we look than about who we are. Forgive us for straining at gnats and neglecting justice, mercy and faith. Cleanse us within; create in us clean hearts. Make us honest before you and one another, through Jesus Christ, who washes us clean. Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 23:23

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Matthew 23:13-33

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Matthew 23:28

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